Slow Strings

“This world we’ve created…” He pauses. The moment steals his voice as he takes it in. “It’s beautiful.”

“It is, isn’t it?”

“You know, you haven’t told me what it’s all for yet.”

“Well, Veryn, it’s a phronimos model for the ‘world’ within each individual to aspire to. Each detail we’ve included, especially the ‘*stars*,’ will inspire humanity.”

Infantile dots of light crowd the ether, ignoring that emptiness that dictates them. Two directors of the scene—Polarys, the oldest dreamer, and Veryn, his aide—scrutinize the formation, comparing it to their blueprints of humanity’s home-to-be.

“And the moment the stars rise to consciousness, *they* will be the first of humanity and the examples for posterity to follow, at least in terms of their linear time. *They* are the **Sovereigns** of the celestial sphere surrounding us. You understand my plan, don’t you?” Polarys verifies.

“Of course, though I wonder how this democracy can stand without your guidance, or at least some form of documentation behind your ‘grand tapestry.’” Veryn comments.

“Maybe you’re underestimating their will to Overcome.”

“Even so, I fear you trust them *too* much.”

“Hm...”

Polarys gazes at the celestial sphere, running his pupils across the night and its candles. His hands clasp together at his waist, twitching with each twinkle from above. The stab of his teeth against his bottom lip leaves a trail of blood down his jaw.

Veryn’s gaze drops from the sky, his body sinking into the ground they built together. His head rests on his palm as he ponders the pond in front of them. A reflection of the heavens gently greets him. “Are their posts being assigned to this planet?” he inquires.

“No, the Earth is in your hands.”

“What?! I thought you said I’d be getting the most important post!”

“Ah, were you under the assumption that the Highest Height would be your responsibility?”

“Obviously. We *both* know what that dreadful castle buries.”

“That place… it’s more suitable to house the Sovereigns. You’ll fare far better at the forefront of humanity.”

“But Pol—”

“I remembered every detail of your request before I came to an ultimatum. Rest assured, Earth is the perfect house for you.”

“Don’t expect me to take shelter in a house without a floor,” Veryn replies. He pauses, turning to Polarys. “A house is not a home. All I hear are excuses without explanations!”

“None of them would satisfy you, my friend. If your curiosity remains, the answers will always be available in your observations.”

Veryn sighs, shaking his head. “With each sentence, you somehow sound more passive than the last. It’s infuriating.”

“Maybe it’s better if you don’t understand me.”

“And why is it that?”

The candles cease their chatter. They wait with bated breath for Polarys' answer. Veryn, too, waits for an answer. Even Polarys waits.

"The world will only meet your eyes halfway. It is up to you whether you bridge that remaining distance." Polarys takes a step forward, a few centimeters closer to the water. "The same principle stands with our intrapersonal worlds. To comprehend mine would require one to burn across an infinite distance."

Veryn frowns and uproots himself from the ground. He puts a hand on Polarys' right shoulder, insisting, "At the very least, I deserve to know. Knowledge is the most basic of freedoms you promised humanity would have, though your actions have been dictating otherwise ever since we engineered these heavy, sweaty bodies. Perhaps the protocols you've limited them with are more demanding than you initially thought."

The contact between the two entities lingers amidst quietude. The dreamer shifts to face his aide, his facial expression now illuminated by the starlight. Polarys' irises are like a page unturned. Veryn recoils in disbelief.

"...Testing these corporeal forms has blinded me; truly, I've lost my pieces. Thank you for returning some."

"Is this why you've been hiding your eyes from mine? So I wouldn't catch your lies?"

Polarys laughs, letting a tear stain his right cheek. “And now they’re whiter than any lie I could tell. Still, I’d rather not burden you with the truth.”

“You idiot,” Veryn scoffs. “No truth can be held by one person alone.”

Polarys’ mouth hangs open, slowly curving into an upwards crescent. “You remember.”

“How can I forget?” Veryn smirks. “Learning kindness means never letting go of it—your words, by the way.”

“Ha! You’re much better than me at handling your Headspace, at least when ensconced in a mortal shell. Shows how appropriate of a pick you are for this post.”

“And why is that?”

“Ah, no other being will be able to protect the people here like you.”

“But the schematics for Kosmos are excellent in that regard!”

“And yet, he will grow beyond those schematics, much like you have with yours.”

“Then, by that logic, every individual will eventually grow in such a way.”

“Yes, that’s exactly my point.”

Veryn’s eyebrows furrow. Wrinkles gather around them. “...What?”

Polarys coughs out a chuckle. “Veryn, I’ve called my plan flawless time after time because I’ve known all of its flaws. Every last one of those flaws is diminished and amplified by one fact: *Nothing* will have a place. It’s humanity’s willpower that will pave the final road.”

“As a collective? A hivemind?”

“No, with each soul.”

Veryn grimaces. “*Impossible*.”

“It sounds impossible, but you know as well as I do of what I gave up to promise humanity a fighting chance.”

“*Yourself*.”

“49% of myself, you mean.”

“You were always so reluctant to outright tell me what you’d accomplished through fragmentation, or where you’d put the fragment.”

“I’m sure it’s not hard to infer these answers now, is it?”

“You’re banking on a miracle at this rate!”

“What else can I do without directly interfering?” Polarys grins, picking at the skin on his left thumb.

“I don’t know, but giving an extra percent to ‘*meet them halfway*’ sounds great to me.”

Polarys passes an audible “*haha*,” rubbing the moisture from his clammy forehead. “And I’m glad you’re *so* enthusiastic about this too.”

The snow of Veryn’s eyes spreads. His hand returns to Polarys’ right shoulder. “For such a risky maneuver, you’ve been pulling the strings so skillfully, albeit slowly.”

“Slow strings make for good music,” the dreamer shrugs.

The aide huffs, sharing the dreamer’s grin. Coolness washes over him as his shoulders release. His eyes return to the pond in front of them. It ebbs and flows as if to nod in

acknowledgement at their conversation. He nods back, his eyes riding on the ripples in the water. *That makeshift sanctuary shall house our secrets*.

The heavens ponder the image trapped within the pond, watching as it winks whenever they wink. They extend their starlight to the water below, and so the water reaches back.

Polarys' eyes light up with the sons and daughters of the ether. "Do you see it, Veryn?"

"See what?"

"Where earth ends, and heaven begins?"

They meet halfway with no delay, overlapping in a pantomime. Veryn's pupils shake with effort, as if attempting to hold the whole world in a singular, mnestic frame. Instead, they settle on the dreamer and the stars in his smile.

"Like grabbing water in a dream, isn't it?" Polarys jokes.

Veryn's eyes inch open at his companion, scanning his arms, legs, face, and eyes until he could recite each vein and its position. *Life-and-death companions, we said. I only hope our words hold true, lest I forever live in this moment*. A laugh more like a cry escapes the aide.

“Yeah. Ask me again, next eternity.”